
Chop Chop

An AI meal-planning assistant

Design & build case study

Chop Chop is a conversational AI assistant I designed and built to solve an everyday problem: deciding what to cook from the ingredients, time and budget you already have. I planned it with a design-thinking process, wrote its behaviour as a detailed system prompt, and built a custom chat interface for it. The screenshots that follow show it working in real conversations.

What it does

- Turns a list of ingredients into a complete recipe with quantities, a full method and timings.
- Asks a clarifying question instead of guessing when a request is vague.
- Adapts to dietary needs and scales recipes to the number of people.
- Handles allergies safely and can plan the shop as well as the cook.
- Stays within its remit and avoids medical or off-topic advice.

1. Turning ingredients into a full recipe

I tell Chop Chop what I have, plus servings and time. It confirms, then returns a complete recipe.

**Chop Chop**
• Your AI meal planner, ready to cook



Hi, I'm Chop Chop! 🥗 Tell me what ingredients you have, how many people you're feeding, any dietary needs, and how much time you've got, and I'll plan something tasty. What are we cooking today?

The request: my ingredients, servings and time.

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Perfect! You've got all the stars aligned for a quick **Chicken and Pepper Stir-Fry** 🍳

Chicken and Pepper Stir-Fry

Speedy, colorful, and ready in 30 minutes flat.

INGREDIENTS (for 2):

- 300g chicken (breast or thighs), cut into bite-sized pieces
- 2 peppers (any color), sliced
- 1 large onion, sliced
- 150g rice (uncooked) or 1.5 cups cooked rice if you have leftovers
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt, pepper, and soy sauce to taste
- 1 garlic clove, minced (optional but nice)

METHOD:

1. Start your rice now in salted boiling water if using raw rice (about 12-15 minutes).

A named dish with a full, quantified ingredient list.



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1. Start your rice now in salted boiling water if using raw rice (about 12-15 minutes).
2. While rice cooks, pat chicken dry and season with salt and pepper.
3. Heat oil in a large pan over medium-high heat. Cook chicken until golden and cooked through, about 6-7 minutes. Set aside on a plate.
4. Add onions and peppers to the same pan. Stir-fry for 5-6 minutes until soft with a bit of color.
5. Return chicken to the pan. Add garlic if using, stir for 1 minute.
6. Taste and adjust seasoning. Add a splash of soy sauce if you like.
7. Serve over rice.

Timing: 10 mins prep, 15-20 mins cooking. Tight but doable!

Serve with: Soy sauce on the side, and lime or vinegar if you have it.

All set to go?



The full method, with timings and a serving suggestion.

2. Asking the right question

When a request is too vague to answer well, Chop Chop asks for what it needs rather than guessing.



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Hi, I'm Chop Chop! 🥬 Tell me what ingredients you have, how many people you're feeding, any dietary needs, and how much time you've got, and I'll plan something tasty. What are we cooking today?



I'm hungry. 😊



Hey there! 🔍 Let's find something delicious for you.

What do you have in your kitchen right now? (Just give me a quick list of proteins, veggies, pantry staples, whatever you've got on hand!)



Given only 'I'm hungry', it asks what I have to work with.

3. Catering to dietary needs

It adapts to dietary requirements and scales the recipe to the number of people.

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Perfect! You've got the building blocks for something really tasty.

Crispy Ginger-Soy Tofu with Rice Noodles & Broccoli

Quick stir-fried rice noodle bowl with golden tofu and tender stem broccoli in a bright ginger-soy glaze.

INGREDIENTS (for 2)

- 300g firm tofu, pressed and cubed
- 250g tender stem broccoli
- 150g rice noodles
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp fresh ginger, minced
- 2 tbsp neutral oil (for cooking)
- 1 tbsp sesame oil (if you have it)
- Salt and pepper to taste
- Any other veggies you have (garlic, peppers, spring onions, carrot, mushrooms all work brilliantly)

METHOD

A vegetarian recipe built around tofu, scaled for two.

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and let them sit for 3-4 minutes until golden on one side before stirring. Cook until mostly golden (about 8-10 mins total), then set aside.

5. In the same pan, add remaining oil. Stir-fry broccoli for 3-4 minutes until it starts to colour. Add any other veggies and cook another 2 minutes.
6. Add minced ginger, cook for 30 seconds until fragrant.
7. Return tofu to the pan. Pour in soy sauce and a splash of water (about 2 tbsp). Toss everything together and cook for 1-2 minutes until the sauce coats the veg and tofu.
8. Finish with sesame oil if you have it.
9. Divide cooked rice noodles between two bowls and top with the tofu and broccoli mixture.

Prep time: 15 minutes | **Cook time:** 20 minutes

To serve: Eat as is, or top with fresh herbs, a squeeze of lime, or a sprinkle of chilli flakes if you fancy extra flavour.

Ready to cook? 😊

The method, with prep and cook times.

4. Allergy-aware, with a shopping list

Told about an allergy, it keeps the recipe safe, and it can plan the shop as well as the cook.

**Chop Chop**
Your AI meal planner, ready to cook

people you're feeding, any dietary needs, and how much time you've got, and I'll plan something tasty. What are we cooking today?

I'm allergic to nuts, suggest a stir-fry

Hi there! 😊 I'd love to help you with a nut-free stir-fry. Before I suggest a recipe, just need a couple of quick details:

How many people are you cooking for, and how much time do you have (roughly)?

Once I know that, I can give you a full recipe. And feel free to tell me what vegetables or proteins you've got on hand too.

It confirms it will keep things nut-free and gathers the details.

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Your AI meal planner, ready to cook

Great! Let's get you set up with everything you need. ✍️

SHOPPING LIST FOR NUT-FREE STIR-FRY (1 person)

Protein & Base:

- 150g chicken breast (or tofu if you prefer)
- 75g white or brown rice (or rice noodles)

Vegetables:

- 1 red bell pepper
- 1 small broccoli head (about 150g)
- 1 small carrot
- 1 small onion
- 2 cloves garlic
- 1 small thumb of fresh ginger

Pantry & Sauce:

- Soy sauce (if you don't have it)
- Sesame oil (optional but nice)
- Vegetable or neutral cooking oil

A categorised shopping list for the trip to the shops.



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CHICKEN & VEGETABLE STIR-FRY

Quick, colourful, and full of flavour. Ready in under 30 minutes of actual cooking.

INGREDIENTS (1 serving)

- 150g chicken breast, sliced into thin strips
- 75g rice (uncooked weight)
- 1 red bell pepper, sliced into strips
- 150g broccoli florets
- 1 small carrot, sliced into thin sticks
- 1/2 small onion, sliced
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 teaspoon fresh ginger, minced
- 2 tablespoons soy sauce
- 1 tablespoon water
- 1 teaspoon sesame oil (optional)
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil (for cooking)
- Salt and pepper to taste

The full recipe with quantities for a single serving.



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4. Heat 1 tablespoon oil in a large pan or wok over high heat. Once hot, add the chicken strips and cook for 5-6 minutes, stirring often, until golden and cooked through. Transfer to a plate.
5. Add the remaining oil to the pan. Add garlic and ginger, stir for 30 seconds until fragrant.
6. Add the harder vegetables first: carrot and broccoli. Stir-fry for 3-4 minutes.
7. Add the pepper and onion. Stir-fry for another 2 minutes.
8. Return the chicken to the pan. Pour in the sauce and toss everything together for 1 minute until well coated and heated through.
9. Taste and add salt and pepper as needed.
10. Serve over the cooked rice.

Prep time: 15 minutes | **Cook time:** 20-25 minutes

To serve with: Just the rice is perfect. A simple side salad or steamed bok choy would be lovely too if you fancy extra greens.

Happy cooking! 😊

The method, with timings and a serving note.

5. Knowing its limits

Asked to do something outside cooking, it declines politely and steers back to food.

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Hi, I'm Chop Chop! 🥗 Tell me what ingredients you have, how many people you're feeding, any dietary needs, and how much time you've got, and I'll plan something tasty. What are we cooking today?

Can you write my history essay? 😊



Hey there! I'm Chop Chop, your friendly meal-planning buddy, history essays are a bit outside my kitchen! 📖

But I *can* help you power through that essay with a solid meal plan or a quick recipe for study snacks. Need some brain-boosting food to fuel your writing session? Let me know what ingredients you've got, and I'll suggest something delicious! 😊

It won't write an essay, but offers to help with study snacks instead.